

ART AND SOCIAL JUSTICE PROGRAMS: DEVELOPING YOUNG PEOPLE



YOUTH STUDIES DEPARTMENT, UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA

KIARRA McCAIN, McNAIR SCHOLAR

DR. ROSS VeLURE ROHOLT, Ph.D.

BACKGROUND

The purpose of the research is to gain an understanding of how certain programs support healthy youth development. Youth development can be described as a process that prepares young people for healthy and productive adulthood. A major criticism of youth development is its lack of capacity to address issues of social injustice (Ginwright, 2006). Social justice youth development theory explores how urban youth contest, challenge, respond to, and negotiate the use and misuse of power in their lives (Ginwright & James, 2002). SJYD programs simultaneously build awareness of self, community, and others (Cammarota, 2011). This study explores two arts-based social justice youth programs, Teens Taking Action and Summer Media Institute, and how they support the development of the young people participating in the programs.

RESEARCH QUESTION

The question that drives this research is "How (if they do) does art based youth programs (when used as a platform to discuss social justice) promote youth development?"

METHODS

The methods for collecting data include:

- Observing conversations, behaviors and responses (verbal and non-verbal) from the young people participating in these programs.
- Facilitating and participating in group discussions.
- Analyzing findings with fellow researchers and research leaders.
- This research utilizes Participatory Action Research (PAR) theory. Research with young people should benefit the researcher as well as the participants. All parts of the research (creating a research question, choosing particular methods, collecting data, analyzing data, and results) are done with the participants. Using PAR methods to collect data, recognizes the participants as knowledge holders, and respects their experiences as tools for teaching. PAR is about listening to what is said and asking questions. More importantly, it's about shared power and acknowledging that the research couldn't be properly conducted without the participation of the community that the research aims to "help".

All photos provided by Google images



DATA THEMES



PRELIMINARY RESULTS

Young people describe these programs as supporting their development. In the program they are supported individually as well as artistically. Indeed, in these programs artistic and identity development appeared to be reciprocal. One supported the other. This was supported by:

- Both programs supported conversations with participants on identity and how different definitions of their identity affect their everyday lives.
- Both programs used art (spoken word in TTA and film in SMI) as a way for young people to discuss their own identity and the challenges they face to develop a healthy identity.

Both programs were experienced as beneficial by the participants. They provided an opportunity for participants to discuss issues they cared about but often were not supported to talk about or to act upon. The programs also created a space for identity exploration and expression that most participants indicated was unique in their everyday lives. Finally, the programs increased participants understanding of social justice issues (homophobia, racism, etc.) and how art can support critical action to address these issues.

DISCUSSION

Joining art and social justice in a youth program creates a community of artists committed to artistic expression and social change. It provides a space for young people to expand their personal identities. The nature of the "Community of Artist", not only allowed the young people to grow artistically, but gave them the opportunity to participate in different roles according to the characteristics they identified as strengths. The elements of SJYD and the dynamics of an art based youth program support young people to develop as individuals and a community.

LIMITATIONS

This study is not generalizable because the sample was convenient and too small to make any generalizations. Time is also another limitation. This study took place over a duration of nine weeks, which restricts the findings.

Special Thanks to Summer Media Institute, Teens Taking Action, Katie Johnston-Goodstar and Ross Velure Roholt

TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM